

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN EL SALVADOR

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in El Salvador, and this small country gave the world one of its most extraordinary proofs. For more than a decade, the farmers of Cabañas, the Catholic Church, water defenders, scientists, and community groups fought a foreign gold mine — the El Dorado project of Pacific Rim, later the Australian-Canadian giant OceanaGold — that threatened the rivers a water-scarce nation depends on. They paid a terrible price: four anti-mining activists were murdered, among them **Marcelo Rivera** and **Dora Alicia Recinos Sorto**, who was eight months pregnant. The company retaliated in another way too, suing the country for hundreds of millions of dollars before a **World Bank investor-state tribunal (ICSID)**. And still the movement won. In **2016 the tribunal ruled for El Salvador** and ordered the company to pay millions in costs — a rare defeat for a mining giant. Then, in **March 2017, El Salvador became the first country on Earth to ban all metal mining**, the Legislative Assembly passing it unanimously, lawmakers holding signs that read "No to Mining, Yes to Life." A tiny, poor country had beaten a multinational and outlawed an entire industry to protect its water, because ordinary people organised, endured, and refused to give up. The law was sweeping: it banned all exploration, extraction, and processing of metals, above ground and below, and the use of toxic chemicals like cyanide and mercury, while leaving non-metallic mining such as salt and stone alone. It built on a de facto moratorium that had held since 2008, when the government first refused Pacific Rim its permit, and it passed with support from across the political spectrum — the Environment Minister of the day called it a historic day not just for El Salvador but for the world.

The mining fight teaches two things about winning in El Salvador — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — mobilisation, the moral weight of the Church, the water argument, national legislation, the courts, the investor-state dimension, and national and international attention — pressed for years until victory became possible. The second is distinctly Salvadoran. The winning lever here was a **national law**, won by a broad grassroots-and-Church coalition around the one argument that unites the country: **water**. That, and the double-edged **investor-state arbitration** system, make El Salvador's fight unlike most others. The scale of that arbitration is worth grasping: the company sued this small, poor country for hundreds of millions of dollars — figures reported between roughly \$250 and \$300 million — before a secretive World Bank tribunal, over a permit it had been denied. The sheer size of the demand backfired, outraging even politicians with little interest in the environment and helping to unite the country behind the ban; and when the tribunal ruled for El Salvador in 2016 and ordered the company to pay some eight million dollars in costs, it proved that these claims, for all their menace, can be beaten.

But the same story carries the hardest lesson of all, and this guide states it plainly: in **December 2024 the Legislative Assembly repealed the ban**, and metal mining was authorised again, now reserved to the state under President Nayib Bukele's government. A historic, world-first victory was reversed seven years later. That is not a reason for despair — the 2017 win proves what this movement can do — but it is a warning that even a landmark legislative victory can be undone, and that the levers available today are narrower than they were, in a political environment far more closed. This guide is written for that harder reality.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They protest once and go home. They assume the project "is decided by the government," and so they never build the water argument, never bring in the Church and the wider coalition, never document the harm, never use the courts or the international system, never sustain the mobilisation that changes outcomes. They generate a burst of anger without a plan to sustain it. The gap between a community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage or numbers. It is method.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Salvadoran system as it is now.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the decision and its weak point)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build proof of harm and of every defect)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(organise a movement that lasts)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES	(the permit, the environment law, the courts, the investor-state dimension)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(make the fight visible and impossible to ignore)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the media story at once; the movement sustains the pressure that decision-makers respond to; a legal fight is a headline and a headline strengthens a case. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The anti-mining movement did exactly this — it documented the threat to water, organised across communities and the Church over many years, fought the ICSID case and pushed for legislation, and made mining a national and international cause, all at once, until the ban passed.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. El Salvador's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The water argument.** In one of the most water-stressed countries in the Americas, where most surface water is already polluted, a threat to water unites the country like nothing else — it was the heart of the mining victory.
- **The Catholic Church.** The Church is a powerful moral and political actor; when priests preached against mining and collected petition signatures at Mass, it changed the national conversation. The Church did not merely issue statements: at Sunday Masses across the country, priests preached the duty to protect creation and the water, and gathered signatures on petitions to the government, turning thousands of parishes into a single national campaign that no other institution in El Salvador could match.
- **National legislation.** El Salvador's decisive win was a **law** — a nationwide prohibition — showing that a broad enough movement can change the rules for the whole country.
- **The environmental-permit system.** Projects need environmental authorisation from the environment ministry (**MARN**) under the environmental law, a formal point of scrutiny and objection.
- **The courts.** The **Constitutional Chamber** and the ordinary courts can review the legality of decisions and defend constitutional rights, including a healthy environment.
- **International and investor-state leverage.** Global attention, solidarity networks, and the reputational stakes of the investor-state system can all be turned to a community's advantage.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers work as they once did. The **2024 repeal** of the mining ban, passed by a Legislative Assembly dominated by the president's party, shows that today **power is highly concentrated** and domestic checks are weak; the state itself is now the would-be miner. Civic space has narrowed under a prolonged "state of exception," and **activists have been arrested and threatened** — five community leaders in the old mining zone were detained in early 2025. The **investor-state system cuts both ways**: a state can win, as El Salvador did, but the threat of a vast arbitration claim can also chill a government. This guide takes those facts seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — and, where an outright stop is not realistic now, how to secure the delay, the exposure, the record, and the rebuilt movement that, in a hard period, are often what progress actually looks like.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Salvadoran development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

Environmental authorisation. Most significant projects need an environmental permit (a **permiso ambiental**) from the **Ministerio de Medio Ambiente y Recursos Naturales (MARN)** under the environmental law (**Ley del Medio Ambiente**), based on an environmental impact study and, in principle, public consultation. This is a key permit and a formal objection point.

National law and policy. Because El Salvador is small and highly centralised — and now especially, with power

concentrated in the presidency and its legislative majority — big questions are often decided at the **national level**: a law, an executive decision, a state project. The mining ban, and its repeal, both happened here, in the Legislative Assembly. That centralisation cuts both ways for a community: it means a distant body may decide the fate of your river, but it also means a national movement, once built, can change everything at a stroke — which is exactly what happened in 2017.

The municipality. Local governments have historically had a role in land use and local consent, and some Salvadoran municipalities declared themselves opposed to mining; local mechanisms remain worth using, though their power has been curtailed.

The courts. The **Sala de lo Constitucional** (Constitutional Chamber of the Supreme Court) and the ordinary and administrative courts can review the legality of decisions and enforce constitutional rights — subject, today, to concerns about judicial independence.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a proposal, to the **environmental impact study and the MARN permit**, through any **consultation**, into the **courts** if challenged, with **national politics** — and, where a foreign investor is involved, the **investor-state dimension** — running alongside, and only then to construction. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The earliest doors are the cheapest and widest: the water argument, a substantive objection at the environmental stage, documentation, the Church and the coalition. The later doors — a court case, a constitutional claim, international pressure — are more demanding and, today, harder, but real. Find out exactly where your project stands on this path; that tells you which door is open now.

Follow the Money and the Water

Behind the project stand a proponent — a foreign mining company, an agribusiness, a developer, or now the state itself — its financiers and buyers, and the officials who authorised it. Trace who owns and funds the proponent, who profits, and who granted the permit. Two questions unlock most Salvadoran fights: **What does it do to the water, and was it lawfully and honestly authorised?** and **Who benefits from pretending it is safe?** In a country this dependent on scarce, already-polluted water, the water answer is often the whole campaign — and where a foreign investor is involved, the financiers and the reputational stakes are reachable pressure points. The context makes the water argument overwhelming: El Salvador is among the most water-stressed nations in the Americas, and by widely cited estimates roughly nine in ten of its surface waters are already contaminated, with the Lempa river — the country's great water source — relied upon by much of the population. Against that backdrop, a project that threatens a river is not one grievance among many; it is a threat to national survival, and it can be argued as such.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **Sala de lo Constitucional** reviews constitutionality; **MARN** supervises environmental compliance; the **Procuraduría para la Defensa de los Derechos Humanos (PDDH)** — the human-rights ombudsman — examines rights violations and can speak for defenders; the **Corte de Cuentas** audits public money. The **Catholic Church** is a moral overseer with unmatched reach, and national and international civil society — the water and anti-mining networks, and global allies — watch throughout. Each overseer is a separate front, reachable with the same evidence, and even in a hard time a project rarely survives sustained pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one door: the same well-documented file — above all the water evidence — can go to MARN, the courts, the PDDH, the Church, the investors, and the national and international press at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close. An El Salvador campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the water argument and the Church as the ones that reach furthest when officialdom is set on a project.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Salvadoran and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project **threatens water** (the argument that wins here), whether the **Church and a broad coalition** engage, whether there is a **clear legal or permit defect**, whether a **foreign investor and the investor-state dimension** are in play, and whether national and international attention can be reached — all weighed against a present reality of **concentrated power, a narrowed civic space, and the state itself as proponent**. Where a water threat meets an organised movement and the Church, El Salvador's levers can still work; where the project is a state priority under the current government, discount the figures and think in terms of delay, exposure, the record, and rebuilding.

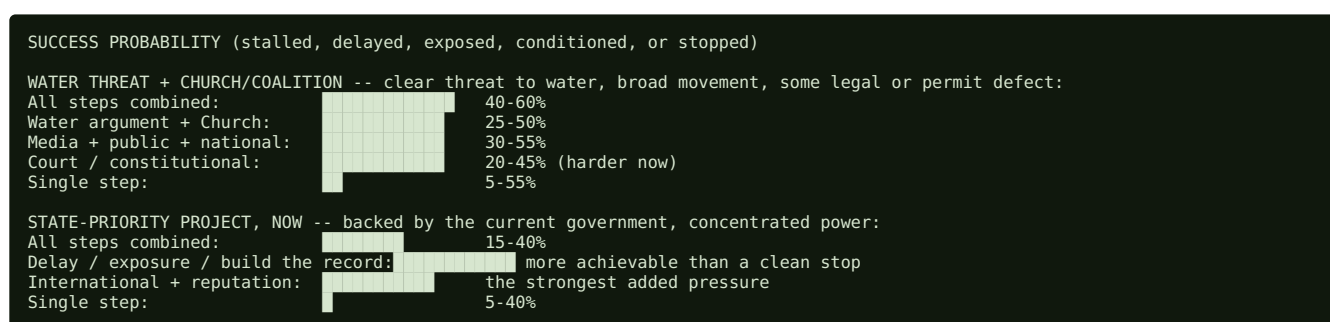
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
The water argument, widely made	25-50%	ongoing	low	Public and political cost raised sharply
Church + coalition mobilisation	25-50%	months-years	low	Moral and political pressure; national reach
Objection at the MARN permit stage	15-35%	during review	low	On record; conditions; grounds
Constitutional / court challenge	20-45%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Decision reviewed or struck (harder now)
Municipal / local opposition	15-35%	months	low	Local consent denied; delay
Human-rights (PDDH) / defender complaint	20-40%	months	low	Findings; protection; pressure
Media & public campaign	30-55%	ongoing	low	Political cost raised; issue nationalised
International / solidarity pressure	30-55%	months-years	low	Investors and reputation engaged
Investor-state (ICSID) defence, if sued	case-specific	years	high (state)	A claim defeated (as in 2016)
National legislation	rare but decisive	years	very high effort	The whole activity banned (the 2017 win)
All steps combined (water threat + coalition)	40-60%	1-5 years	low-moderate	Stalled, exposed, conditioned, or stopped
All steps combined (state-priority project, now)	15-40%	1-5 years	low-moderate	Delayed, exposed; the record built for later

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and El Salvador's real strengths are distinctive — the **water argument**, the **Catholic Church**, the possibility of **national legislation**, the **environmental-permit** process, the **courts**, and **international and investor-state leverage**. Its constraints, today, are severe: **concentrated power** and a compliant legislature, a **narrowed civic space** with risk to activists, the **state as proponent** since the 2024 repeal, and the chilling **threat of investor-state claims**.

A note on cost: the water argument, coalition-building, objecting at the permit stage, and complaining to the PDDH are inexpensive. Court cases cost more, and are harder now. The investor-state arena is a different world — costly and state-level — but the lesson of 2016 is that a state, backed by an organised public and skilled lawyers, can win even there. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is the patient organising and the Church-and-water coalition that, over a decade, produced a world-first law.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in El Salvador are **the water argument, the Church and coalition, and public mobilisation** everywhere, and **the courts and legislation** where the political moment allows. The mining fight shows the ceiling: a decade of organising won a defeat of a mining giant and a world-first national ban. But the 2024 repeal shows the floor of this moment: a concentrated power can reverse even a historic win, and the state can become the miner. Most Salvadoran fights today sit between them, and the honest lesson is that the water argument, the Church, and mobilisation are real and distinctive levers — but against a state-priority project under the current government the realistic near-term win is often delay, exposure, protection of your people, and a record and a movement rebuilt for a better moment, as much as an outright stop. Use the table to plan, not to predict: it tells you which

combinations have historically done the most work and where to put scarce time first. The single most important reading is that no row on its own is as strong as the rows run together — the community that makes the water argument, enlists the Church, objects at MARN, documents the threat, and reaches the world at once consistently outperforms the one that pins its hopes on any single move, especially in a moment when any one lever can be overridden.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The water argument and public mobilisation** — El Salvador's decisive lever; the threat to scarce water that unites the country, as it did against mining.
2. **The Catholic Church and the broad coalition** — the moral authority and national reach that turned the mining fight, and that no government dismisses lightly.
3. **The environmental permit and the courts** — the MARN authorisation and the constitutional and legal review, where a defect or a right can be pressed (harder now, but real).
4. **International and investor-state leverage** — the solidarity networks, the reputational stakes, and the hard-won knowledge that a state can beat an ICSID claim.
5. **The record and the rebuilt movement** — in a closed moment, the documentation and the organisation that keep a cause alive until it can win again.

What Salvadoran Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Water wins arguments** — the mining ban was, at heart, about protecting water. **The Church is decisive** — its moral weight nationalised the fight. **Persistence pays** — the victory took over a decade. **A state can beat an investor-state claim** — El Salvador did, in 2016. **But even a historic win can be reversed** — the 2017 ban was repealed in 2024 — and today power is concentrated and civic space narrow. The through-line: **make the water argument everywhere; bring in the Church and the widest coalition; object at the permit stage and use the courts while you can; understand the investor-state dimension; reach the nation and the world — and, in this hard moment, protect your people, build the record, and keep the movement alive, expecting delay and exposure as much as a clean stop, and knowing that what was won once can be won again.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point. Vague opposition to "the mine" goes nowhere; opposition to "the environmental permit sought for a project that would contaminate the river a hundred thousand people drink from, without the honest impact study and consultation the law requires" is a case. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What exactly is proposed, and what does it do to the water? Name the project, the proponent, and — first, always, in El Salvador — **what it does to the water**: which river, aquifer, or watershed, and who depends on it. Then the specific instrument it needs: the **MARN environmental permit**, a concession, a state authorisation. Water is both the strongest argument and often the clearest harm. Establish it precisely and early: name the source, count the people and farms that depend on it, and gather the baseline data before any works begin, so that a later change can be proven rather than merely asserted. In a country where clean water is already scarce, that single fact — this project endangers the water of these specific people — will do more to move neighbours, parishes, journalists, and even wary officials than any number of abstract environmental appeals.

2. What stage is it at? Proposal? Environmental impact study under way? MARN permit sought or granted? Consultation held (or skipped)? A state project announced? In the courts? Under construction? The stage dictates the door. If the permit is live, the water argument and a substantive objection are the route now; if it is granted or a state project is under way, the courts, the coalition, and public pressure are the route.

3. Is there a real permit, study, and consultation — or a clear defect? Does the project have a valid **MARN permit** and an honest **environmental impact study**, or does it understate the threat to water? Was the community genuinely consulted? A missing permit, a whitewashed study, or a skipped consultation is often the strongest legal ground.

4. Is a foreign investor — and the investor-state dimension — involved? Is the proponent a foreign company that could invoke, or be exposed by, the **investor-state (ISDS/ICSID)** system? This shapes both the risk (a chilling claim, as Pacific Rim brought) and the opportunity (international leverage, and the lesson that such claims can be beaten).

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which officials authorised it; who owns, funds, and profits from the proponent (including the state); which communities, parishes, and organisations are affected; and which lawyers, the Church, the PDDH, press, and international allies can be reached. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a mining or heavy-industrial project is proposed that would draw on or contaminate a river many communities drink from, with an environmental permit sought and a foreign investor behind it.

Working the five questions: the decisive fact is **the threat to the water** — so build that first and hardest. The project needs a **MARN permit** (live — object now, get the impact study). If the **study understates the water harm** or **consultation was skipped**, those are legal grounds. A **foreign investor** means the **investor-state dimension** is in play — a risk to weigh and a source of international leverage. And with power concentrated, the **water argument, the Church, the coalition, and international attention** carry more weight than quiet appeal to officials.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the mine" to a target list: build and broadcast the water argument; get the impact study and object at MARN; bring in the parish and the coalition; document the threat; assess the investor-state angle and international allies; prepare a court challenge where a defect exists; protect your leaders; and prepare the water-and-community story for national and international press. That is a campaign, not a complaint. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse fear into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — build the water argument, object at MARN, enlist the parish, document the threat, protect your leaders — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin today. That is the difference the five questions make, and it is what turns anger into a movement.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A judge, a MARN official, a bishop, a journalist, an international ally, and a project's investors all move on evidence, not indignation. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Official Record

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **environmental impact study and the MARN permit** (or proof there is none); any **concession or state authorisation**; and the **consultation record**. Some is public or obtainable on request; a refusal is itself a documentable fact. The gap between what the paper claims — a safe project, an adequate study, a real consultation — and what the science and the law require is where cases are won. The mining fight turned on exactly this kind of proof: that the project threatened the water in ways the company's assurances denied. Read whatever documents you obtain against the grain, for what they concede or omit — an impact study that says little about the watershed or the long-term risk of acid drainage, a permit that glosses over the community's objections, a consultation "record" that is really a single announcement. In a fight where the science is on the side of the water, the gap between the paper and the reality is usually where the case is strongest.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth — Above All, the Water

Document the reality the paper hides, and put water at the centre. Sample and record the **water** — the river, the aquifer, the wells, the quality, the people and farms that depend on them — because in El Salvador the water evidence is the case; independent testing, with the help of scientists and universities, is invaluable. Photograph and date the **site** — the works, the tailings or discharge points, the affected land and homes — and geotag it. Log **incidents**: contamination, fish kills, a lowered or fouled water source, works beyond permit. Capture **before-and-after** with your own photos and with freely available satellite imagery. Record **testimony** from residents, farmers, health workers, priests, and independent experts on the threat to water and health.

Layer 3: The Defects and the Rights

Finally, document the failures of process and the legal lines the project crosses. Is there **no valid MARN permit**, or a **whitewashed impact study** that understates the water harm? Was **consultation skipped or faked**? Does the project threaten the **right to water and a healthy environment**, or the health and livelihoods of communities, in breach of the Constitution and the environmental law? If a **foreign investor** is involved, what are the investor-state exposures and opportunities? Each defect is a separate ground — for an objection, a court case, a constitutional claim, a PDDH complaint, or an international appeal — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often

decides Salvadoran fights, because here a project that looked authorised is revealed to threaten the nation's water, to rest on a false study, or to violate a right the Constitution protects. Work it methodically against each requirement: is there a valid MARN permit; is the impact study honest about the water, the watershed, and the cumulative and long-term harm; was the community genuinely consulted; does the project threaten the right to water and a healthy environment? Where the answer is no, capture the proof — because each “no” is a separate ground an objection, a court, the PDDH, the Church, or an international ally can act on, and the water and permit grounds are the ones that move a Salvadoran audience fastest.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Salvadoran cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's particular defect — and, above all, the water evidence.

The Water, the Permits, and Their Paper Trail

- **The environmental impact study and the MARN permit** — read the study for what it understates about the water, the watershed, the health effects, and the cumulative impact. A missing or invalid permit is often the decisive defect.
- **Water data** — independent testing of the river, aquifer, and wells, and the baseline that shows what is at stake; scientists, universities, and water organisations can help. In El Salvador this is the heart of the file.
- **Any concession or state authorisation** — and, since the 2024 repeal, the terms on which the state itself may pursue or license mining.
- **The consultation record** — evidence of whether the community was genuinely consulted, or whether a process was staged or skipped.
- **The investor details** — the foreign company, its subsidiaries (some kept a Salvadoran presence even under the ban), its financiers and buyers, and any investor-state exposure.

How to Get Them

Environmental records are held by **MARN**; concessions and state authorisations by the relevant ministry; consultation records by the municipality and MARN. Use El Salvador's access-to-public-information law to obtain what is not volunteered; a refusal or silence is itself evidence, though be aware that transparency has narrowed and requests may go unanswered. Work with the **water and anti-mining networks** (the National Roundtable Against Metallic Mining tradition and its allies), universities, and the Church, which hold expertise, testing capacity, and records a lone community cannot assemble. Move early: an objection entered while the environmental permit is under review, and water baselines taken before the works begin, carry far more weight than the same point made later — and the deadlines for court challenges are strict. A practical note: pair every water sample and site photograph with a date, a location, and, where you can, an independent witness or a laboratory, so the evidence stands up when the other side disputes it; and keep duplicates in more than one place, because in a narrowed civic space a file held only in one pair of hands is a fragile thing. The water evidence, well gathered and safely kept, is the single most durable asset an El Salvador campaign has.

The Ground Evidence

- **Independent water testing and monitoring** — the single most valuable evidence in an El Salvador fight: contamination, heavy metals, cyanide or mercury risk, flow and supply, mapped to the people who depend on the source.
- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the site, the works, the discharge points, the affected homes and fields.
- **Satellite before-and-after** from freely available imagery, to show clearing, tailings, or the true extent.
- **Health and livelihood evidence** — clinic records where available, testimony of illness, harm to crops and animals, mapped to the water source.
- **Maps** overlaying the project, its discharge, and the watershed on the communities and their water — a single map of a mine upstream of a city's drinking water is worth pages of argument.
- **Testimony** — from residents, farmers, health workers, priests, and independent scientists.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the study, the permit, the consultation, the works, and every incident and deadline — the spine of any court case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an

argument bank (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a volunteer, a lawyer, a bishop, a journalist, and a judge all see the same clear picture fast — and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the other side challenges it. In a fight that can run for years — the mining victory took more than a decade — the community with the better-kept file, above all the better water evidence, is very often the one that prevails, and the file outlasts a bad political moment to power the next fight.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE A MOVEMENT THAT LASTS

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Organised people do — sustained, visible, and credible over the years a fight takes. This is the step the anti-mining movement did best: a coalition of farmers, the Church, scientists, and communities that held together for over a decade, through the murder of its own members, and won.

Phase 1: The Core, and the Parish

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people who will carry the work. In El Salvador, root it early in the **parish**: the local Catholic community and its priest are a natural, legitimate, and protective centre of gravity, as they were in Cabañas. A parish brings things a campaign cannot easily create for itself: a trusted meeting place, a weekly gathering, a leader with moral standing, a network that reaches every household, and — in a dangerous time — a measure of protection, since an attack on a church-backed movement carries a cost the powerful would rather avoid. Begin there, and much else follows. It was in the parishes of Cabañas that the anti-mining movement first cohered, and it was the Church, more than any other institution, that carried the cause from those parishes to the nation. Assign roles: water and documentation, legal liaison, Church and coalition liaison, media, community liaison, and — a necessity here — security and the protection of leaders. Agree on the goal — a permit refused, a project stopped, a state plan halted, the water protected — and on what you will and will not accept.

Phase 2: The Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in **neighbouring communities, farmers, the Catholic Church at every level up to the bishops, scientists and universities, water committees, students, and health workers**. Reach the **allies with capacity** — the national water and anti-mining networks (the **Mesa Nacional Frente a la Minería Metálica** tradition, MOVIAC, and community associations like the Cabañas groups), human-rights organisations, and the international solidarity networks (Friends of the Earth, MiningWatch, and others) that carried the Salvadoran case to the world and the UN. The mining victory drew its power from exactly this breadth — communities, Church, scientists, and global allies in one movement — which is precisely the spread a winning campaign needs, and the only spread that can sustain a fight through a hostile political moment. The Salvadoran movement also reached deliberately outward: it drew on the experience of partial mining bans in Costa Rica, Argentina, and Colombia, and international allies such as Friends of the Earth carried the case all the way to the United Nations, in the push for a binding treaty on business and human rights, while groups like MiningWatch amplified it across the Americas. That international layer was not decoration; it was leverage, and — for activists in danger — a measure of protection.

A worked coalition example. Facing a mine threatening a river, the affected communities and their parishes form the base; the bishops lend moral authority; scientists document the water threat; the national anti-mining network and human-rights groups bring legal and organising capacity; and international solidarity partners raise the profile and reach the investors. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the water evidence, the moral argument, the law, the local roots, and the global reach — the model that produced a world-first ban.

Phase 3: Sustaining It — and Protecting People

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and in El Salvador they must also reckon with real danger. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — a strong objection, a batch of water data, a parish that takes up the cause, a wave of coverage. Rotate the exhausting roles. And, with utmost seriousness, **protect your people**: this movement has buried its martyrs, and today activists face arrest and threat under a narrowed civic space. The cost has been real and human: four anti-mining activists were murdered during the Cabañas struggle, among them Marcelo Rivera, a community leader, and Dora Alicia Recinos Sorto, killed while eight months pregnant — and their families still seek justice. That history is why protection is not an afterthought in an El Salvador campaign but a first-order duty of its leadership. Keep leadership collective and visible; document every threat and act of intimidation; work closely with the Church, human-rights organisations, and the PDDH; build international links that make harm to a leader an international

matter; and take security advice as a standing practice, not an afterthought. Sustaining a campaign safely — as the anti-mining movement did over a perilous decade — is how these fights are won.

Phase 4: Showing Strength

Numbers and legitimacy must be seen. Turn people out for Masses, processions, permit hearings, and peaceful, well-documented gatherings — the Church's spaces have historically been the safest and most powerful for this. Let the **water argument and the moral voice of the Church** lead. Make the fight a national story and, where you can, an international one. Be clear-eyed about the risks of protest in the current environment and take advice on safety and law. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate, to MARN, the courts, the government, the investors, and the world, that the community, the Church, and the public are united, watching, and not going away.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE PERMIT, THE COURTS, AND THE INVESTOR-STATE DIMENSION

Salvadoran law gives communities real tools, though today they must be used with clear eyes about a weakened judiciary and a concentrated executive. You do not need a final ruling to win with them: an objection, a court filing, or an international appeal delays a project, forces disclosure, and creates leverage and headlines. Engage lawyers and the networks early — but understand the tools yourself.

The Environmental Permit

The first lever is the permit process. Most significant projects need an environmental authorisation from **MARN** under the **Ley del Medio Ambiente**, based on an impact study and, in principle, public consultation. Object substantively while the permit is under review, putting your strongest water evidence on the record; a deficient study, an understated threat to water, or a skipped consultation is a ground to demand refusal or conditions and to challenge the permit later. Even where the political will favours the project, the record you build here is the foundation of every other step.

The Courts and the Constitution

El Salvador's Constitution and laws protect rights that a project may cross — and the country has recognised the **human right to water and a healthy environment**. The **Sala de lo Constitucional** can hear constitutional challenges (including the *amparo*), and the administrative and ordinary courts can review the legality of permits and decisions. Be realistic: concerns about judicial independence under the current government mean these remedies are less reliable than they were, and a favourable ruling is harder to obtain and enforce. But a well-built legal case still forces disclosure, creates delay, builds the record, and preserves the ground for a better moment — and, occasionally, still wins.

National Legislation — the Lever That Won Before

El Salvador's greatest victory came not through a single permit or lawsuit but through a **national law**: the 2017 ban on all metal mining, the fruit of a decade-long movement. That lever is the hardest of all to reach — it requires a broad enough coalition to move the Legislative Assembly — and today, with power concentrated and the ban already repealed, it is not available in the short term. But it is worth remembering what it proves: that a movement, patient and broad enough, can change the law of the land, and that a law once repealed can, in a better political season, be won again. Keep that horizon in view even while fighting project by project. It also shapes tactics now: every objection filed, every water study gathered, every parish and community organised, and every abuse documented is not only a move in today's fight but a brick in the coalition and the evidentiary record that a future legislative push would rest on. The 2017 ban did not appear from nowhere; it was the accumulated weight of a decade of exactly such work, and the next such victory will be built the same way.

The Investor-State Dimension

A distinctive and double-edged feature of El Salvador's experience is the **investor-state (ISDS/ICSID)** system. Few communities will need to litigate one of these cases themselves — they are fought at the level of the state — but every community facing a foreign investor should understand the dimension, because it shapes what a government will say and do. A government may plead that it cannot refuse a project for fear of a ruinous claim; the answer, grounded in El Salvador's own history, is that such claims can be resisted and defeated, and that the mere threat of one is not a reason to surrender a nation's water. Knowing this turns a weapon the other side hopes will silence you into an argument you can

turn back on them. A foreign investor denied a permit may sue the state for a vast sum before an international tribunal, as Pacific Rim did — a real chilling threat. But El Salvador's history holds the crucial lesson: in **2016 the country won**, the tribunal rejecting the claim and ordering the company to pay costs. If your fight involves a foreign investor, understand this dimension: it is a risk a government will cite, but it is also a source of powerful international leverage and solidarity, and the proof that these claims can be beaten with a strong case and public backing.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Objections go to **MARN**; constitutional and legal challenges to the **Sala de lo Constitucional** and the courts; rights and defender complaints to the **PDDH**; and international appeals to solidarity networks, UN mechanisms, and — where relevant — the inter-American human-rights system. Get help early: El Salvador's anti-mining and water networks, human-rights organisations, and their international partners know exactly these procedures and can advise on the strongest ground, the strict deadlines, the water case, the investor-state angle, and — vital now — how to protect the people bringing the fight. Help engaged while the permit is live, and before deadlines and dangers close in, is worth far more than help sought after the machinery and the risks arrive.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a judge, a MARN official, a bishop, a journalist, an international ally, an investor, and the community itself in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a mine upstream would contaminate the river a hundred thousand people drink from, on a permit resting on a study that hid the risk. That one fact becomes:

- **A water argument:** the project threatens the drinking water of an already water-scarce nation — the argument that unites El Salvador and won the mining ban.
- **A moral argument:** it endangers God's creation and the poor who depend on the river — the language the Church made powerful.
- **A legal argument:** the permit rests on a deficient study and threatens the right to water and a healthy environment — grounds for objection and a court case.
- **A media argument:** a foreign company poisoning a nation's water for gold — a vivid, resonant story.
- **An international argument:** a project exposing its investors and the state to reputational and legal risk, and the world to another assault on a water-poor country — the frame that drew global solidarity.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in El Salvador the arguments that most often decide things are the **water one**, because it unites the country, and the **moral one**, because the Church carries it further than any other voice. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the court file and a claim made at Mass can be proven in the water data; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive, and protective.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts and MARN want the illegality framed precisely against the specific rule — the environmental law, the permit conditions, the right to water and a healthy environment — with the documents, the water data, and the timeline that prove it.

The Church responds to the moral stakes — the threat to creation, to the poor, to the water of the community — expressed plainly and truthfully.

Journalists need a specific, verified, human story with a hook: a named river, a community, a foreign company, a documented threat, a live decision.

International allies and investors respond to reputational and legal exposure — a project poisoning a water-poor nation's rivers, tied to a named company and its financiers, with the investor-state stakes in view.

The community itself needs to see that the fight is winnable and shared — and safe enough to sustain — so it lasts through years and a hard political moment. Show it the small, concrete wins — the objection lodged, the water data

gathered, the parish that took up the cause, the international ally that wrote — and show it that its leaders are protected; a community that can see progress and feels safe is a community that endures, and endurance is what won before.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever. Coverage raises the political cost of a project, reaches officials, reaches the foreign investors your letters cannot, protects activists by making them visible — a real safeguard where defenders are at risk — and can turn a local fight into a national and global cause. The mining movement proved it: the water argument and the story of a country fighting a mining giant, carried by the Church and international allies, made a tiny nation the unlikely hero of a global cause and helped win a world-first law.

Build the Story

Reporters need specifics: a named place and stake, a dated and documented threat or harm, and a live decision. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a foreign company's mine would poison the river a hundred thousand people drink from, in a country where most water is already contaminated" is. Lead with your strongest verified fact — above all the water — attach the map and the testing data, and offer a human and moral voice: a resident, a farmer, a priest, a scientist. In El Salvador the water-and-faith story is uniquely powerful.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community media** first, and the **Church's own channels**, which reach deep into communities. Then **national outlets** — El Salvador's independent press and online news — which carry the story into national politics, mindful that the media environment has narrowed. Then, because the country's story resonates globally and its projects often rest on foreign investment, **international media and solidarity networks**, which reach the investors, the diaspora, and the world; the mining case became a global story precisely this way. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. In El Salvador the **international ring is especially important now**, both for leverage and for the protection that visibility gives activists. It is worth identifying the specific national reporters who cover the environment, water, and human rights, and the international correspondents and solidarity outlets who follow Central America, mining, and defenders; a journalist who already knows the terrain needs less briefing and carries more weight, and a single vivid, well-sourced story — a river at risk, a community defending its water — can move opinion and reach investors more than months of quieter effort.

Sustain It, Make It Safe and True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and, in a long fight, must be sustained for years. Plan a sequence — the water data, the permit fight, the court case, the international appeal, the action — so there is always a next hook, and build your own record (a simple page, a social feed, a growing album of dated photographs, video, and water results) so the story exists in a form journalists can pick up and that survives if posts are removed. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; one exaggeration handed to the other side can cost credibility you cannot rebuild, and in a tense environment accuracy is also protection. Weigh safety in every choice, coordinate with the Church and human-rights bodies on when and how to raise a profile, and never expose a vulnerable individual for a headline. Verified, specific, water-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law, the water evidence, and the moral stakes.

8A. Objection at the MARN Environmental Permit Stage

To: the Ministerio de Medio Ambiente y Recursos Naturales (MARN) **Subject:** Observaciones — permiso ambiental, [project]

As a community/person affected by [project] at [location], we object to its environmental authorisation. Our grounds, with evidence: (1) the impact study [understates/omits] the threat to [the river/aquifer] that [#] people depend on; (2) [the project risks contamination by [heavy metals/cyanide/mercury]]; (3) [consultation was inadequate]. We attach independent water data. We request that the permit be **refused**, or granted only on strict conditions, and that our objection be formally answered.

8B. Access-to-Information Request

To: [MARN / the relevant ministry / the municipality] **Subject:** Solicitud de información pública — [project]

Under the access-to-public-information law, we request: the environmental impact study and permit for [project]; any concession or state authorisation; the consultation record; and the water-monitoring data held by the authority. Please respond within the legal period. We note the public interest in information affecting the water supply.

8C. Letter to the Parish / Diocese (seeking the Church's voice)

To: [the parish priest / the bishop] **Subject:** [Project] — a threat to our water and our people

We write as members of this community about [project], which threatens [the river/aquifer] that our families and neighbours depend on for drinking water and livelihoods. We fear [contamination/harm to health and creation]. We ask the Church's help in defending our common home and our water: to give voice to this concern, to accompany the affected communities, and to help us protect our people. We attach what we have documented.

8D. Instructing Lawyers / the Anti-Mining Network

To: a human-rights or environmental lawyer / the water and anti-mining network **Subject:** [Project] — legal options and protection

We believe the [permit / authorisation] for [project], of [date], is unlawful and dangerous because [the study understates the threat to water / consultation was skipped / it violates the right to water and a healthy environment]. We attach the study, our water data, and our timeline, and seek advice on an **objection**, a **court or constitutional challenge**, and — where a foreign investor is involved — the **investor-state** dimension. We also need guidance on protecting the people leading this fight.

8E. Letter to an Investor / Financier / Buyer

To: [the investor / parent company / financier / buyer] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and human-rights risk

We write regarding your [investment in / financing of / purchasing from] [company] in connection with [project] at [location]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "would contaminate the drinking water of tens of thousands in one of the world's most water-stressed countries"], and our documented concerns include [the water threat, the deficient study, the community's opposition, and the history of harm to activists]. We remind you that El Salvador has both banned this activity before and defeated an investor-state claim over it. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and human-rights risk, and whether your own [commitments] are consistent with it. We are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Letter to a Legislator / Official

To: [a deputy of the Legislative Assembly / a relevant official] **Subject:** [Project] — concerns and request

We are residents of [place] writing about [project]. Our concern, briefly: [one or two specific grounds — the threat to the water of [#] people, a deficient permit]. Within your responsibility, we ask you to [refuse or review the authorisation / protect the water and the affected communities]. [If true:] many communities, and the Church, share this concern. We welcome a meeting and can share our full evidence.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the river / the community]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear news hook: [documents and water data] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a foreign mine would contaminate the river a hundred thousand people drink from, in a country where most water is already polluted"], with [a decision] due [date]. It is specific, verified, and it echoes the fight that made El Salvador the first country to ban metal mining. I can share the full file and connect you with

residents, a priest, and a scientist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Human-Rights / Protection Alert (PDDH and allies)

To: the Procuraduría para la Defensa de los Derechos Humanos (PDDH), copied to human-rights allies and the press

Subject: Protection concern — defenders opposing [project]

We report that leaders and members of the community opposing [project] face [threats / intimidation / arrest / surveillance]: [sourced facts, dates]. Given El Salvador's history of violence against anti-mining defenders and the current risks, we request [monitoring / investigation / protective measures], and we are informing human-rights organisations, the Church, and the press. We attach the record of incidents.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a demanded-but-refused consultation, or an ignored objection, is itself evidence, and a documented pattern of threats is vital for protection and for any international step. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law, the water evidence, and the moral stakes; attach your documentation, water data, and maps; and route them, where you can, through the parish and the Church, your lawyers and the networks, and your international allies. The reply — or the silence — becomes part of your record, and in El Salvador that record feeds the levers that matter most: the water argument, the Church, the permit and the courts, and national and international attention — with the safety of your people and the endurance of the movement guarded above all.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Make the water argument — loudly and everywhere.** In El Salvador nothing moves people and politics like a credible threat to drinking water. State it plainly, tie it to a named river and the people who depend on it, and repeat it (8A, 8G).
- 2. Bring in the parish and the Church.** A letter to your priest or bishop (8C) can enlist the one institution with unmatched moral reach — the force that helped win the mining ban.
- 3. Object at the MARN permit stage and demand the documents.** A substantive objection and an information request (8A, 8B) put your grounds on the record and can force disclosure and conditions.
- 4. Reach the water and anti-mining networks.** They bring testing, legal help, and national reach a lone community cannot (8D) — and guidance on protecting your people.
- 5. Protect your leaders and document threats.** In this environment, safety comes first: keep leadership collective, document intimidation, and alert the PDDH and allies (8H).
- 6. Reach the world.** International solidarity and press (8E, 8G) engage the investors and the reputational stakes, and help keep activists safe.
- 7. Build the record for the next chance.** Even if you cannot stop it now, the documented case and the movement can win in a better season — as the ban itself once did.

Do only the first three and you will have made the water argument, enlisted the Church, and put your grounds on the official record — the exact foundation the mining movement built on. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: water, the Church, the record. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, sustained over years, produced a world-first law from a standing start — they are not a consolation prize but the proven core of how El Salvador wins. Everything else in this guide amplifies those three moves.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

El Salvador's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that

still work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt is steep right now, and openly so. **Power is concentrated** in the presidency and a legislative supermajority that repealed a historic law in 2024; the **state itself is now the would-be miner**, so the referee and the player can be the same. The repeal law that reauthorised mining in December 2024 provides that only the president's government may authorise or carry out mining — directly, through institutions it creates, or through companies in which it holds shares — which is what makes the state both regulator and beneficiary. The president, who once called the ban “absurd” and pointed to vast supposed gold deposits, commands a legislative supermajority, so the ordinary checks that might restrain such a project are, for now, largely absent. **Judicial independence is in doubt**, making the courts a less reliable check. A prolonged “**state of exception**” has narrowed civic space, and **defenders face arrest and threat** — community leaders in the old mining zone were detained. And the **investor-state system** can be cited by a government as a reason to yield to a foreign company, even as it also offers leverage. Where this tilt bites, the ordinary process gives far less than it should — but real levers still reach past it.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts, real and distinctive levers reach past it.

Water is a near-universal argument. In a country this water-poor, a credible threat to drinking water moves even unsympathetic politicians and a wary public — it always has.

The Church has independent reach. No government controls the pulpit; the Church's moral voice and organising capacity are a power in themselves, as the mining fight showed.

International attention and solidarity are outside the state's control. The press, the diaspora, solidarity networks, UN and inter-American mechanisms, and the reputational stakes of foreign investment can all be reached past a closed domestic system.

The record endures. What you document — above all the water evidence — and the movement you build outlast a bad political moment and power the next fight.

A win is possible again. The country banned mining once and can do so again; nothing about the 2024 repeal is permanent.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for El Salvador is demanding, and this guide will not pretend the present moment is anything but hard. The water argument, the Church, the possibility of national legislation, the permit process, the courts, and international and investor-state leverage give a community real — in places distinctive — power, as the world-first ban proved. But power is concentrated, the ban is repealed, the state is the proponent, the courts are doubtful, and defenders are at risk. So diagnose the tilt honestly: lean on the water argument, the Church, mobilisation, and international attention, not on the goodwill of officials; use the permit and the courts to build the record and win delay; protect your people above all; and think in terms of exposure, delay, and a movement and a case kept alive for a better season, as much as an outright stop today. What was won once can be won again — and the movement that endures is the one that will win it.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Sometimes a project advances not through honest error but through undue influence — a permit granted against the evidence, a study waved through, land quietly bought up around a planned mine, a decision that serves a private or political interest rather than the public. When that is what you face, your strategy shifts: you stop trying to persuade a captured decision-maker and start exposing and going around them.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **permit granted despite a clear threat to water**; an **impact study that reads as a formality**; **land agents quietly buying up plots** and offers of “social programs” around a planned project, as

residents in the old mining zone reported; community leaders in that zone — among them Antonio Pacheco, a long-standing organiser — were arrested in early 2025, and defenders such as Vidalina Morales have described living in fear since the repeal; **consultation skipped or staged**; a **regulator that looks away**; and **pressure, surveillance, or arrests aimed at opponents**. In the current environment, where power is concentrated and the state may itself be the proponent, be especially alert to decisions that serve the project regardless of the evidence. One anomaly may be error; a pattern is capture.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where undue influence reaches. **Ministries, regulators, and — with power concentrated — much of the domestic apparatus** can be aligned behind a favoured project, and the courts' independence is in doubt. But even now, some bodies and audiences are far harder to control: the **Catholic Church**, with its own moral authority; the **international press and solidarity networks**; **foreign investors and financiers** answerable to their own regulators and reputations; **UN and inter-American human-rights mechanisms**; and the **watching public**, for whom a threat to water is a powerful mobiliser. Undue influence thrives on darkness and on staying domestic; your task is to lift the matter into the light — and, in El Salvador especially, out to the Church and the world.

What to Do

Do not confront and tip off the captured decision-maker. Instead, **document the anomaly precisely** — the permit against the evidence, the sham study, the land-buying, the pressure on opponents — and take it, with evidence, to the bodies and audiences beyond its control: the Church, the international and national independent press, the solidarity networks, the investors and financiers, the UN and inter-American mechanisms, and the public through the water argument. Pair the exposure with the water case and the moral argument, so the wrongdoing and the threat surface together. And protect yourself above all — the danger to defenders here is not theoretical, as the movement's martyrs and the recent arrests attest: take security and legal advice, keep the work collective and documented, involve the Church and human-rights bodies, and never carry it alone.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in El Salvador can be a years-long marathon, as the mining victory was.

Early (Weeks 0-8): Water, the Church, and the Record

Pin down the project, the instrument, and — first — what it does to the **water** (Step 1). Root the campaign in the **parish** and the affected community (Step 3). Move at once on what is cheap and time-sensitive: **make the water argument**, **write to the parish and the Church** (8C), **object at MARN and request the documents** (8A, 8B), and **begin the water evidence and the file** (Step 2). Reach the **anti-mining and water networks** early (8D), and put protection of your people in place from day one. This phase costs little and lays the foundation for everything else.

Middle (Months 2-24): Escalate on Every Front

Grow the movement and coalition, with the Church and the networks (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **court or constitutional challenge** where a defect exists, the **PDDH** complaint, the **investor-state** analysis (Step 4). Expose any corruption to the Church, the press, and the world. Reach the **investors and international allies** (8E). Build the media drumbeat from local and Church channels to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the fast, time-sensitive things first — an objection lodged, water baselines taken, a threat documented — because those chances do not return. And sequence the moves so they land when they bite hardest — the water argument made the moment the project is known, the objection filed while the permit is open, the water baseline taken before the works begin, the protection put in place before the pressure comes — because in El Salvador, as the long mining fight showed, the fights are won by those who move early and then endure.

Later (Months 6-48+): Sustain, Protect, and Keep the Cause Alive

Sustain the movement against burnout and fear; **protect your people** as the first priority; keep the record and the coverage alive. Pursue what is achievable — a **permit refused or conditioned**, a **project delayed or stopped**, a **wrong exposed**, the **water protected**, the **international pressure sustained** — and, where an outright stop is not possible now, **build the case and the movement for a better season**, remembering that the ban itself was the fruit of

more than a decade. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped. Often, in this moment, it is a project delayed and exposed, defenders kept safe, and a cause carried forward — which is not a lesser victory but the groundwork of the next one.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8 Water argument | Enlist the Church | Object at MARN + request docs | Start water evidence | Protect people
MONTHS 2-24 Grow the coalition | Arguments | Courts + PDDH + investor-state | Investors + international | Media
MONTHS 6-48+ Sustain | Protect people first | Win delay / refusal / exposure / protect the water | Build for the next chance

FINAL ASSESSMENT

El Salvador gives communities a genuinely powerful — and, in places, distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits, which in the present moment are severe.

The strengths are real and distinctive. The **water argument** unites a water-poor country like nothing else; the **Catholic Church** lends a moral authority and reach no government controls; **national legislation** is a lever this country has actually pulled, banning an entire industry; the **environmental-permit process and the courts** offer formal points of scrutiny and challenge; and **international and investor-state leverage** — the solidarity networks, the reputational stakes, and the proven fact that a state can defeat an ICSID claim — reach past the domestic system. These are the levers that, combined over a decade, made a tiny nation the first on Earth to ban metal mining.

The limits are just as real, and this is a hard moment. Power is concentrated in a presidency and a supermajority that repealed the historic ban in 2024; the state itself is now the would-be miner; judicial independence is in doubt; civic space has narrowed under a state of exception; and defenders face arrest and threat, in a movement that has already buried its martyrs. No guide should pretend otherwise. The repeal of a world-first law shows that even a landmark victory can be reversed — that hard fact is the condition of this fight, not its exception.

So the realistic promise is this: **make the water argument everywhere; enlist the Church and the widest coalition; object at the permit stage and use the courts to build the record and win delay; understand and use the investor-state dimension; reach the nation and the world; and, above all in this moment, protect your people and keep the movement and the case alive — running all of it together.** Do that, and even in a closed moment you can force delay, exposure, protection, and the safeguarding of your water, and lay the ground for the day the law can be won back. Do it as the people of Cabañas and their allies did — turning water, faith, and stubborn solidarity into a defeat of a mining giant and a world-first ban — and you can protect not only your own river but a precedent that showed the world what a small, determined country can do.

A last word on endurance. El Salvador's great victory took more than a decade and cost lives, and its reversal came in a single vote; both facts belong to this fight. The proponent and the state are counting on your exhaustion and, now, your fear. Their advantage is power, money, and the machinery of a concentrated state; yours is the one argument that unites the country — water — a Church that will not be silenced, a public that has stopped mining before, a world that is watching, and the plain truth that you are defending the water your children will drink while they pursue a return. Play to that. Keep the file and the water evidence, keep the Church and the community united, keep the record and the coverage alive, protect your people first, and treat every objection, every batch of water data, every sermon, every wave of international attention, and every defender kept safe as a brick in a wall that a bad political season cannot tear down — and that a better one can build upon.

The tools are here, and El Salvador itself proved they can work: a tiny country beat a mining giant and banned an entire industry to protect its water. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, endurance, and collective courage — and those you supply, as the farmers and parishes of Cabañas supplied them through a decade of danger. Begin today, begin cheaply, and build from there. Communities before you have stopped, delayed, and even outlawed what looked unstoppable — a mining giant defeated in a World Bank tribunal, an entire industry banned by a unanimous vote, a nation's water defended by farmers and their Church against every advantage of money and power. The tools that did it — the water argument, the Church, the coalition, the courts and the law, the world's attention — are still here, and the only thing the 2024 repeal truly changed is that the fight must be waged again, and won again, by a movement patient and brave enough to outlast a bad season. What was won once can be won again. So can yours.